

Aepyceros melampus

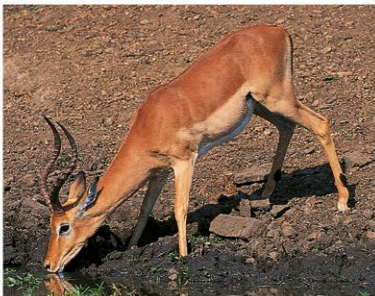
Impala



Length 3½–5 ft
(1.1–1.5 m)
Tail 10–16 in
(25–40 cm)
Weight 88–145 lb
(40–65 kg)
Location E. and southern
Africa
Social unit Group
Status Least concern



Impala are noisy antelopes. Males (which are horned) make loud, hoarse grunts when rutting; calves bleat; and all emit loud warning snorts as they race off with high leaps, kicking the hind legs out straight and landing on the forelegs. Adaptable grazer-browsers, impala form mixed herds in the dry season. At breeding time, bachelor males compete for territories and females. The coat is reddish fawn with black streaks on the hips and tail.



Litocranius walleri

Southern gerenuk

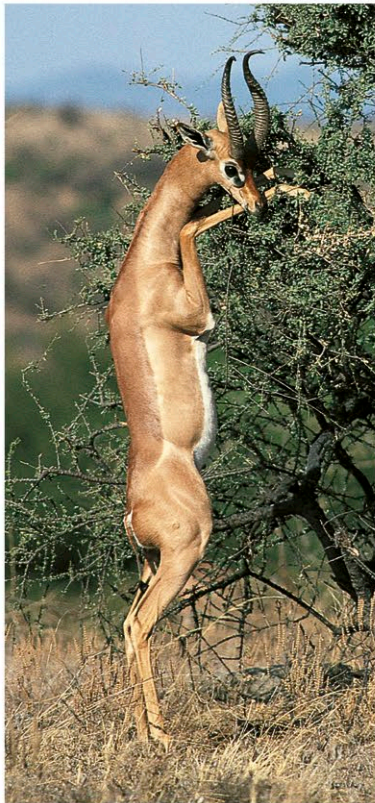


Length 4½–5½ ft
(1.4–1.6 m)
Tail 9–14 in
(22–35 cm)
Weight 62–115 lb
(28–52 kg)
Location E. Africa
Social unit Individual/Group
Status Near threatened



Also called the giraffe-gazelle, the southern gerenuk has a very long, slender neck and similar legs. It can curve its spine into an S shape, balancing its weight over its rear legs, in order to stand vertically for long periods. This allows it to browse higher than similar-sized herbivores in open woodland and scattered bush. Seen from the front, its neck, head, and long, wedge-shaped muzzle are extremely narrow, for probing into acacias and other thorny foliage. The southern gerenuk uses its long, pointed tongue, mobile lips, and sharp-edged incisors to pluck and nip the smallest leaves. It is mainly reddish fawn, with a broad, dark band along the back and upper sides, and white on the underparts, neck, chin, lips, and around the eyes; the tail is black tufted. Only the males have horns, which are 14 in (35 cm) long, relatively thick and curved. Social units are male–female pairs, or small groups

of one male and 2–4 females, with offspring. Only territory-holding males breed, from about 3 years old. Younger males form bachelor herds, although one male may attach to the periphery of a female band, and the occasional female may be solitary.



Antidorcas marsupialis

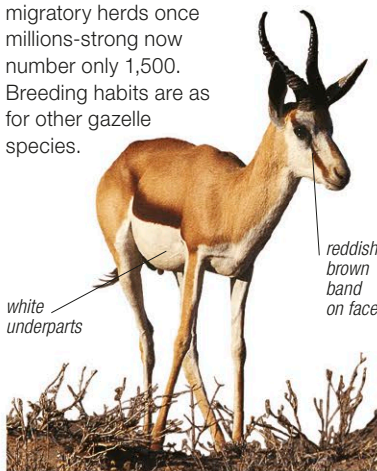
Cape springbok



Length 4–4½ ft
(1.2–1.4 m)
Tail 6–12 in
(15–30 cm)
Weight 60–65 lb
(27–31 kg)
Location Southern Africa
Social unit Group
Status Least concern



The Cape springbok is among several bovids that “stott” or “pronk”—leap stiff-legged, high and repeatedly, as if bouncing. This behavior may serve to deter predators. This adaptable herbivore is highly gregarious, but migratory herds once millions-strong now number only 1,500. Breeding habits are as for other gazelle species.



Eudorcas thomsonii

Eastern Thomson’s gazelle



Length 3–4 ft
(0.9–1.2 m)
Tail 7¼–10¼ in
(19–26 cm)
Weight 33–55 lb
(15–25 kg)
Location E. Africa
Social unit Group
Status Near threatened



This small gazelle is graceful and speedy. It “stotts” (see springbok, above right) energetically when threatened by, for example, many of the big cats, hyenas, jackals, and similar carnivores, for which it is a staple part of their diet. The most common gazelle in its region, it some times forms mixed herds with impala and other gazelle species. It mainly grazes short grasses, yet also browses. Small herds of 10–30



RAPID BREEDING

Thomson’s gazelle is one of the few bovids that can breed twice yearly. The first calf is born in January or February, after the rains; the second in July. A newborn is quickly on its feet, but spends the first few weeks lying hidden until it can keep up with the herd. It is weaned by 4 months.



dark, ringed horns
(longer in the male,
shown, than in the
female)

dark
fingerlike
pattern on
inside of ear

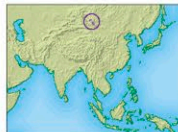
females and young join male bachelor bands, and even lone males, to migrate between grasslands (in the rainy season) and bush (when it is drier). Thomson’s gazelles usually produce a single offspring, which is born after about 180 days’ gestation. Although initially mottled darker than the parent, the coat of the young gazelle lightens in 1–2 weeks.

DISTINCTIVE MARKINGS

A black flank band separates the sandy fawn back from the white underside. The rufous head has a darker blaze, and white eye-rings that extend along the muzzle, above the black cheek stripes.

Saiga mongolica

Mongolian saiga



Length 3¼–4½ ft
(1–1.4 m)
Tail 2¼–4¾ in
(6–12 cm)
Weight 57–150 lb
(26–69 kg)
Location C. Asia
Social unit Group
Status Critically endangered



This medium-sized Asian “goat-antelope” has an enlarged nose with down-pointing nostrils, perhaps to control body temperature and/or give a keen sense of smell. The thick, woolly coat is cinnamon-buff above, paler on the underparts, and thickens greatly for winter. The Mongolian saiga lives in semi-desert areas on low-sloping, rather than flat, steppe and eats varied plants. Smaller breeding groups join to form larger herds for migration. Only males of the species have horns.

